

STAY BARTERS

THE PLAY BOOK

*How to build a professional website for a place — in exchange
for a free stay.*

Interview · Photography · Build · Launch · Handoff · May 2026

"You arrive as a guest, leave as a collaborator — the owner gets a website that drives direct bookings, you get the stay paid in skill."

OVERVIEW

PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHEN
1. Find	Spot a property that would benefit	Before booking
2. Pitch	Propose the trade	Via email or in-person
3. Prepare	Research, plan the content	Before arrival
4. Interview	Capture the story	Day 1 of the stay
5. Shoot	Photograph everything	Days 1–2
6. Build	Code the site	During or after the stay
7. Launch	Domain, GitHub Pages, handoff	Final day or within a week

Typical stay needed: 2–3 nights minimum. Longer for complex properties.

PHASE 1

FINDING THE RIGHT PROPERTY

Look for places that have something real but no web presence (or a bad one):

GOOD SIGNS

- Listed on Airbnb/Booking but no standalone website
- Unique story or setting — farm, lake, jungle, family-run

- Owner is hands-on and communicates personally
- Reviews exist but guests have to dig to find them
- Priced reasonably (not a 5-star resort — they already have agencies)

RED FLAGS

- Already has a good website → no trade value
- Corporate-owned → no owner relationship
- No personality / nothing to tell a story about

PHASE 2

THE PITCH

Keep it simple and human. This works best in person or over WhatsApp.

WHAT TO SAY

SCRIPT

"I build websites for places I love staying at. I'd like to trade — I'll build you a professional website that helps you get direct bookings (no Airbnb commission), in exchange for [X nights]. You keep everything — the code, the domain, all of it."

WHAT YOU'RE OFFERING

- A 4-page website with their story, photos, facilities, reviews, and a direct WhatsApp booking link
- A GitHub repo they own forever
- A custom domain (first year covered, ~\$10–20)
- A handoff guide so they can update it themselves

Typical trade: 2–4 nights depending on property size. Agree upfront.

PREPARATION (BEFORE ARRIVAL)

- Check if they have existing Airbnb/Booking/TripAdvisor — note reviews, star rating, review count
- Note any social media (Instagram, Facebook)
- Think about the domain name (e.g. `aji-fruit-farm.lk`, `mamadwinery.com`)
- Bring: a camera or phone with a good lens, tripod if possible, a notebook
- Clone or copy the template folder, name it after the property

PHASE 4

THE INTERVIEW

Do this on Day 1. Record audio if they're comfortable, or take notes. Ask in their language if possible — translate later.

ORIGIN STORY

- How long have you been running this place?
- How did you come to own it / start this?
- What was here before?
- What changed along the way?

WHAT MAKES IT SPECIAL

- What do you want guests to feel when they arrive here?
- What do guests say when they leave?
- What can guests get here that they can't get anywhere else nearby?

THE PRACTICAL STUFF

- What's included in the price? (Breakfast? Transfers? Activities?)
- What's check-in / check-out?
- What activities do you offer on-site?
- What's nearby that you can arrange? (safari, horse riding, day trips)
- Do you have a pet / family members / staff involved?

HONEST EXPECTATIONS

- What should guests know before they arrive? (cold showers? no restaurant nearby? nature very close?)
- Who is this place *not* for?

BOOKING LOGISTICS

- What's your WhatsApp number?
- What message do you want guests to send when they inquire?
- Do you have a minimum stay?
- Do you have seasonal pricing?

REVIEWS

- Are you on Airbnb / Booking / TripAdvisor?
- Can I use real quotes from your reviews on the website?
- What's your star rating and approximate review count?

SOCIAL / CONTACTS

- Do you have Instagram or Facebook?
- Do you want a contact email on the site?

PHASE 5

PHOTOGRAPHY

Shoot across the stay, not all at once. **Golden hour (6–8am, 4–6pm) is mandatory for outdoor shots.**

MUST-HAVE SHOTS

CATEGORY	WHAT TO CAPTURE	COUNT
Hero / establishing	Full property from distance — golden hour, landscape in context	2–3
The setting	Lake, garden, orchard, jungle, view. Mist, fruit, animals. Atmosphere.	4–6
Exterior	Building from outside, entrance/door, veranda, path to the room	3–4
Interior — room	Full room from doorway, the bed (clean linen), unique feature, seating area	4–6
Bathroom	Full shot + feature shot if unusual (open-air, outdoor shower, vessel sink)	2–3
Food	Full breakfast spread, close-up of local dish, fresh produce from the land	4–6
The host	Candid portrait while doing something — tending farm, pouring tea, working	2–3
Activities	Kayaking, safari, hiking, pool — whatever's available. 1–2 per activity.	3–6
Details	Fruit on tree, textures, morning light, architecture — fill grids with these	5–10

TECHNICAL NOTES

- **Landscape (horizontal)** for hero images, split sections, and photo grids
- **Portrait (vertical)** for bathroom shots and some room details

- No harsh noon sun — shoot in shade or wait for golden hour
- Don't over-edit — natural colors, just lift shadows slightly
- Optimize to 200–400KB per image before uploading (use **squoosh.app**)

PHASE 6

BUILDING THE SITE

THE STACK

LAYER	CHOICE	WHY
HTML/CSS/JS	Vanilla — no framework	No build step; owner can edit directly
Fonts	Cormorant Garamond + Inter	Boutique/editorial feel
Hosting	GitHub Pages	Free, reliable, HTTPS auto-provisioned
Domain	Namecheap / local registrar	~\$10–20/yr
Booking CTA	WhatsApp wa.me/ link	No integration needed
Map	Google Maps embed	Free, no API key for basic embed
Reviews	Static HTML, copy from Airbnb	No third-party widget

PAGE STRUCTURE — THE 4-PAGE MODEL

PAGE	FILE	WHAT'S ON IT
Homepage	<code>index.html</code>	Hero, welcome, host intro, rooms teaser, setting, activities, food, reviews, contact + map
The Room	<code>rooms.html</code>	Full-width photo slider, specs, amenities list, honest note, book CTA
The Place	<code>place.html</code>	Hero, photo grids, setting, activities, food carousel, book CTA
Our Story	<code>story.html</code>	3-act narrative: Before → Crisis/change → Now. Pull quote. "See the rooms" bridge.

A minimal build can compress to **1 page** (everything on index.html). Use 4 pages for richer properties.

HOMEPAGE — SECTION BY SECTION

SECTION	WHAT IT DOES	KEY ELEMENT
Nav	Logo + links + Book Direct button	WhatsApp link on the button
Hero	Full-viewport photo + property name + tagline	CTA button "See the rooms"
Welcome	2-column: copy left, photo right	Sets the scene in 3 sentences
Meet the host	2-column: photo left, copy right	Host quote in italic
Rooms teaser	3-photo grid → links to rooms page	Main (veranda/exterior) + 2 side (bed, bathroom)
The setting	2-column: photo + copy	Lake / garden / nature
Activities	3-column cards with photos	Distance badge overlay
Food	2-column: copy + photo	Breakfast / local food
Reviews	Rotating quotes + star rating	Gold stars + platform count
Find Us	Dark bg: address + WhatsApp + map	Google Maps iframe
Floating button	Fixed bottom-right, always visible	WhatsApp icon

DESIGN SYSTEM

```
:root {
  --bg:      #f0ede4; /* warm linen - main background */
  --bg-alt:   #e8e2d6; /* alternating sections */
  --bg-dark:  #1b3826; /* deep forest green - CTAs, footer */
  --text:     #18180f; /* near-black */
  --muted:    #6b6856; /* body copy, labels */
  --wa-green: #25d366; /* WhatsApp button */

  --font-display: 'Cormorant Garamond', Georgia, serif;
  --font-body:    'Inter', system-ui, sans-serif;
}
```

Change `--bg-dark` to match the property's character:

SETTING	COLOR	HEX
Farm / jungle	Deep green	#1b3826
Desert / arid	Warm terracotta	#7a3b2e
Coastal	Navy	#1a2e4a
Vineyard	Burgundy	#4a1e2e

WHATSAPP CTA — THE MOST IMPORTANT ELEMENT

Put this on every page: floating button, nav button, dark footer section. Pre-fill the message.

```
https://wa.me/[COUNTRY_CODE][NUMBER]?text=Hi%20[Name]%2C%20I%20found%20your%20farm%20online%20and%20I%27d%20love%20to%20book%20a%20stay.%20Could%20you%20tell%20me%20about%20availability%3F
```

REVIEWS CAROUSEL

- Store 5–6 real quotes in a JS array: `{ text: "...", author: "Name, Country" }`
- Pull exact quotes from Airbnb/TripAdvisor reviews
- Show ★★★★★ in gold (`#c8952e`) + platform count below

- Rotate on dot click with opacity fade

PHASE 7

DOMAIN & DEPLOYMENT

GITHUB PAGES SETUP

1. Create a public repo: `[property-slug]` (e.g. `ajis-mango-farm`)
2. Push all files to the `main` branch
3. Go to repo Settings → Pages → Source: `main / / (root)` → Save
4. GitHub gives you: `[username].github.io/[repo-name]`

CUSTOM DOMAIN — DNS RECORDS

Add these 4 A records + 1 CNAME in the registrar's DNS settings:

```
A      @      185.199.108.153
A      @      185.199.109.153
A      @      185.199.110.153
A      @      185.199.111.153
CNAME  www    [username].github.io
```

Then in GitHub Pages settings → Custom domain → enter the domain → Save.
HTTPS auto-provisions within ~1 hour after DNS propagates.

CNAME FILE

Create a file called `CNAME` in the repo root with one line — the domain:

```
your-domain.com
```

WHERE TO BUY DOMAINS

REGISTRAR	BEST FOR	COST
Namecheap.com	.com / .co / .net	~\$10–15/yr
Cloudflare.com	.com (cheapest, at-cost pricing)	~\$8–10/yr
Local registrar	Country TLD (.lk, .co.il, etc.)	~\$15–30/yr

PHASE 8

HANDOFF

The owner gets everything. Walk them through it in person or on a call.

- GitHub repo URL (public — they can clone or fork)
- `OWNER-GUIDE.md` — plain-English instructions for updating text and photos
- Domain credentials (transfer to their registrar account if bought for them)
- WhatsApp number confirmed working in all booking CTAs
- HTTPS confirmed active
- Owner added as GitHub collaborator with push access

README to write in the repo: What the site is, the page structure, photo inventory (which photo is in which slot), how to update, Claude Code instructions for future AI-assisted edits.

REFERENCE

TIME & COST

ITEM	TIME	YOUR COST
Interview	1-2 hours	—
Photography	2-4 hours	—
Photo editing / resize	1-2 hours	—
Building (simple, 1-page)	4-8 hours	—
Building (4-page model)	12-20 hours	—
Domain (first year)	—	\$10-30
Hosting (GitHub Pages)	—	Free
Total you cover	~16-28 hours	~\$10-30

A 3-night stay at a \$50/night guesthouse = \$150 of value for ~\$20 in costs.

FROM STAY #1

LESSONS FROM AJI FRUIT FARM

WHAT WE LEARNED

- **Get the real story.** The most compelling copy comes directly from the owner's words — especially the crisis/turning-point chapter. Don't write generic "welcome to our beautiful property" copy.
- **Cold showers = a feature, not a bug.** Honest expectations build trust. Put the disclaimer directly on the rooms page — it pre-qualifies visitors and reduces disappointment.
- **WhatsApp pre-fills convert.** The booking message should be pre-written and URL-encoded. Visitors send it with one tap.
- **4 pages beat 1 page.** The 4-page model lets each page tell a complete story. The story page drives emotional connection. Guests who read it become bookers.
- **Never use close-up abstract shots as teaser images.** Every photo in a grid must answer one of: *What does the setting look like? What is the room like? What makes it unique?* A blurry door handle answers none of these.
- **Review quotes need to be real.** Copy exact quotes from Airbnb/TripAdvisor. Attribution ("— Momoyo, Japan") makes them credible.
- **Roles stay clean.** Photographer doesn't code. Builder doesn't art-direct the shots.

QUICK REFERENCE

GITHUB PAGES IP ADDRESSES

```
185.199.108.153
185.199.109.153
185.199.110.153
185.199.111.153
```


GOOGLE FONTS IMPORT

```
<link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Cormorant+Garamond:ital,wght@0,300;0,400;0,600;1,300;1,400&family=Inter:wght@300;400;500&display=swap" rel="stylesheet" />
```

GOOGLE MAPS EMBED

```
<iframe  
  src="https://maps.google.com/maps?q=[LOCATION]&t=&z=13&ie=UTF8&iwloc=&output=embed"  
  width="100%" height="100%" style="border:0;" allowfullscreen loading="lazy">  
</iframe>
```

PHOTO OPTIMIZATION

- Target: **200–400KB** per image
- Format: JPG for photos, SVG for icons
- Max dimensions: 2400px wide for hero, 1600px for others
- Tool: **squoosh.app** — free, browser-based, no install